Annual Report - Formal Complaints

July 1, 2024 – June 30, 2025

Prepared by:
PPS Office of Civil Rights

Introduction

This report fulfills PPS Board Policy 4.50.030-P requiring an annual update to the Board on the District's formal complaint process. It covers formal complaints received and decided between July 1, 2024 and June 30, 2025 ("reporting year") and summarizes data highlights, trends, and process improvements.

During the reporting year, families may raise issues or concerns about their students' schools or classrooms. Portland Public Schools (PPS) welcomes these expressions as opportunities to learn, clarify intentions, and drive continuous improvement that benefits all students. We are committed to working with families to address concerns promptly and fairly.

Most concerns are resolved at the school level (see the Conflict Resolution page for pathways). The District also provides a Complaint Coordinator, housed within the Office of Civil Rights, who helps families access information, connect with staff, and navigate resolution options.

When an issue meets the criteria for a formal complaint under the District's Formal Complaint Policy and Oregon Administrative Rule (OAR) 581-022-2370, PPS follows the formal complaint process.

Types of Complaints

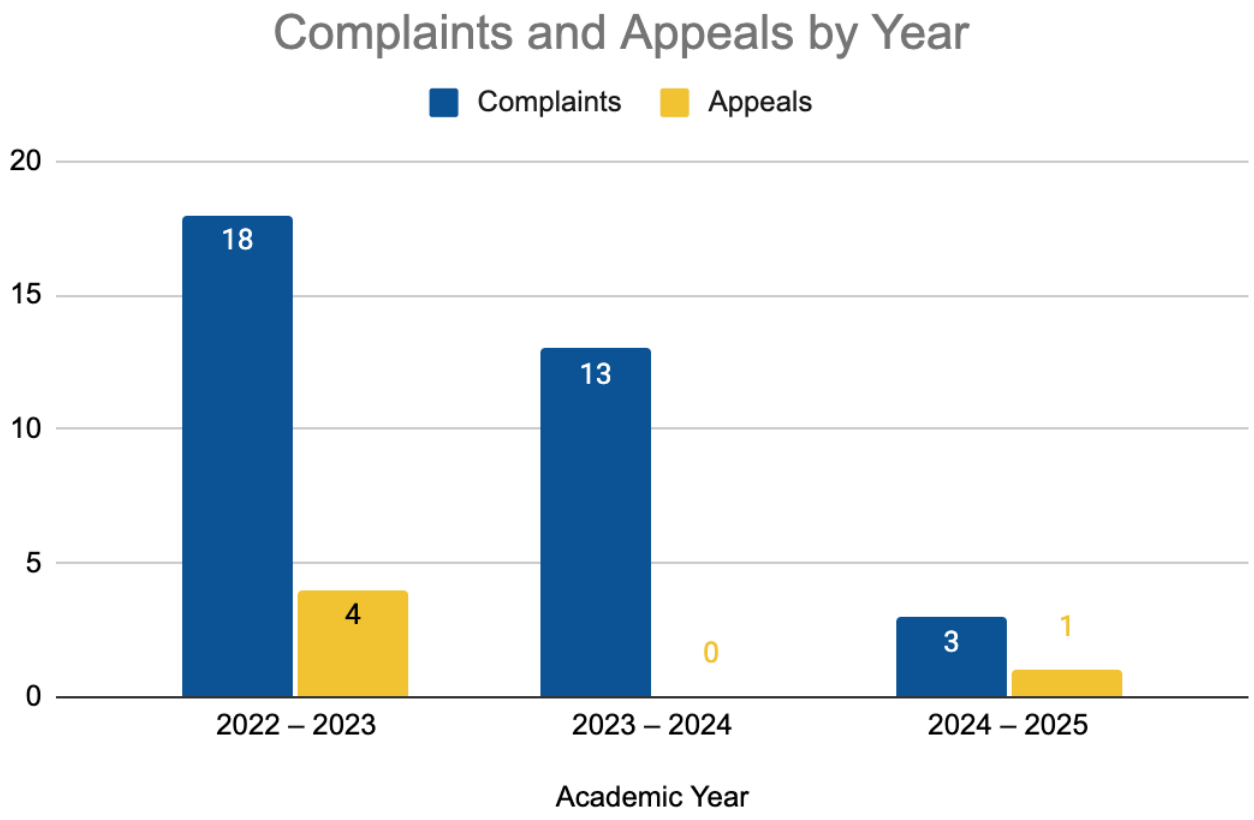
PPS accepts Division 22 formal complaints under Board Policy 4.50.030-P and OAR 581-022-2370 on the following topics (examples are illustrative, not exhaustive):

- Instructional standards and practices
    - For example, curriculum, teaching strategies, testing/assessment, counseling, class size, instructional materials, and compliance with state standards.
- Special education programs (program-level issues; not individual student disputes)
    - In most cases, special education complaints are redirected to the Oregon Department of Education
    - Individual student Individuals with Disabilities in Education Act (IDEA) and/or Section 504 disputes follow Oregon Department of Education (ODE) process rather than Division 22 guidelines

- Health and safety
- Equitable education opportunities
- Sports safety
- Restraint and/or seclusion
- Bias or discrimination in education
- Retaliation against a student or parent/guardian
- Failure to investigate complaints of bias

Complaints and Concerns - By the Numbers

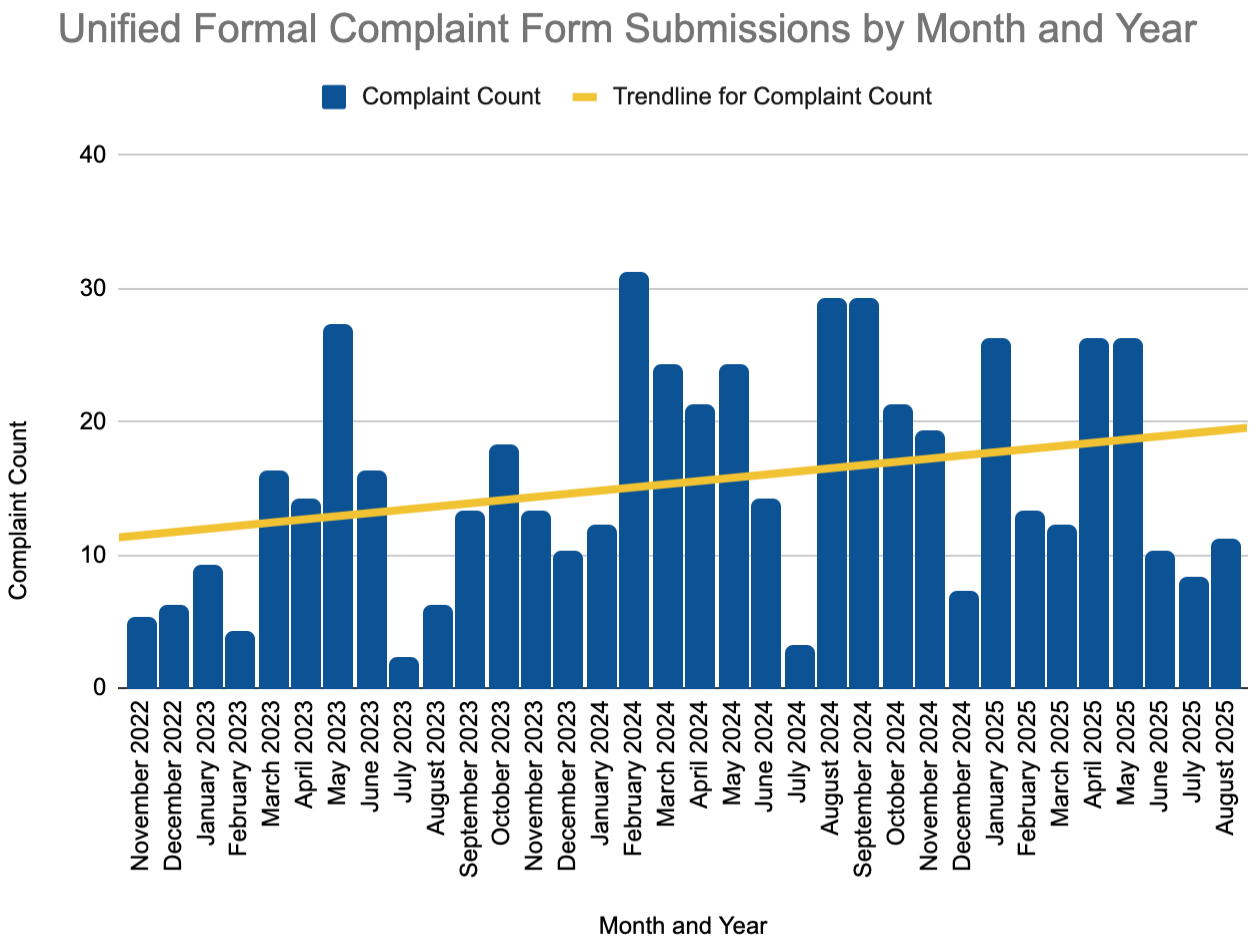
Below is a three-year snapshot of the number of Division 22 (formal) Complaints and Appeals received by and responded to by the District.



New formal Division 22 complaints declined from 18 in 2022 – 2023 to 13 in 2023 – 2024, to three during the 2024 – 2025 academic year. The pattern reflects stronger classification and early-resolution practices, not only changes in concern volume. Following the creation of the Office of Civil Rights in July of 2024, the team has consistently applied the District's administrative directives during intake to determine whether a report meets Division 22 criteria

or should be routed to a specialist pathway such as Title IX, Section 504/ADA, or site-level problem solving. Staff also conduct proactive outreach to complainants to clarify issues, offer supportive measures, and explore resolution options without unnecessary escalation. As a result, more concerns are routed correctly at the outset, while reports that do meet Division 22 are investigated under Board Policy 4.50.030-P and OAR 581-022-2370. Triage of potential Division 22 concerns always includes input and review from legal counsel.

Next is a chart showing the number of Unified Complaint Form (UCF) submissions by month since the form was released in November 2022. The chart below does not account for other concerns that are sent directly to the Complaint Coordinator by email (complaintcoordinator@pps.net), are reported by phone, or are referred by district and school staff. The vast majority of concerns that are processed by the Complaint Coordinator, estimated at more than 90% of total, are submitted through the UCF submission process.



Regarding the increase in submissions, we believe that a higher number of submissions does not necessarily indicate an increase in concerning issues at schools. As access improves, especially through the Unified Complaint Form, concerns that previously arrived by informal

phone calls or emails are now recorded in one place. Centralized intake helps us respond more consistently and improve district practices over time.

Trend of 2024 - 2025 Division 22 Complaints

In most years, this report includes an analysis of Division 22 concerns reported to PPS during the most recently-completed academic year. In this instance, the sample size of reported concerns is so small (three formal complaints) that an analysis is not particularly relevant, as one cannot draw conclusions about trends based on what was reported.

The themes of received Division 22 Complaints for the 2024 - 2025 school year is limited to:

- Discrimination in Education: Section 504
    - Count: 2
- Equitable Educational Opportunities: Access to Compacted Math
    - Count: 1

Concerns Outside of Division 22 Criteria

Most concerns that reach the Complaint Coordinator, whether through the UCF or by email or phone, do not meet the state's Division 22 criteria for a formal complaint. That does not mean they go unanswered. These concerns typically involve individual student supports (special education or Section 504), transportation, student behavior and discipline, Title IX or other civil-rights issues, school-based peer conflicts, neighborhood matters around schools (parking, traffic, community interactions), staff or workplace concerns, records requests, and other site-specific issues. When a concern falls outside Division 22, we route it to the team best positioned to help and follow up with the family.

When receiving concerns that fall outside of Division 22 criteria, our process is:

1. Intake and safety check. We review the concern to understand the issue and to identify any school, student, or community safety risks. Urgent safety issues are escalated immediately.
2. Legal review when needed. If the issue involves legal requirements or protected rights, we consult with PPS Legal to confirm the correct next steps.
3. Routing to the responsible team.
    a. For school-based issues, we share the concern with the school principal and the Senior Director who oversees that school.
    b. For district program or policy issues, we share the concern with the department or subject-matter lead responsible for that topic or program.
    c. For personnel or staff conduct issues, we share the concern with Human Resources.

    d. In some cases, more than one of the groups above will be involved. If the matter belongs to another agency (for example, the Oregon Department of Education or law enforcement), we inform the complainant which agency is responsible and how to contact them.
4. Acknowledgment to the complainant. We confirm receipt, identify who is now handling the concern, explain what to expect next, and offer a point of contact for any follow-up questions.
5. Documentation. We record the triage, routing, communications, and closure steps in the Complaint Coordinator's tracking system.

From July 2024 through June 2025, Portland Public Schools received 206 submissions through the Unified Complaint Form. This figure reflects UCF submissions only; it does not include concerns received through other channels such as email, phone, staff referrals, Connect with PPS, Safe Oregon, ParentSquare, or the Title IX reporting form. Because families can contact us in several ways, we track and respond across all channels; however, the 206 total is limited to UCF forms. For clarity, this count reflects forms submitted, not necessarily unique issues, because one form can include more than one topic and multiple contacts about the same situation may be consolidated during follow-up.

In Summary

Perhaps the most pertinent takeaway from the data above is that PPS continues to receive a growing count of reported concerns, year-over-year, since the inception of the Unified Complaint Form in November of 2022. By providing an easy, accessible reporting mechanism, PPS allows for increased conversation, early resolution, and timely and proper routing. Most concerns are responded to within two business days. Exceptions rarely occur when concerns are particularly complex, involving multiple departments and/or stakeholders.

While responsiveness is a priority, so is accuracy to decrease confusion and ensure that responses are efficiently routed to meet the needs of complainants. Documentation also plays a critical role in ensuring that there are artifacts for reference in the event that there are recurring concerns. Taking the time to hear from complainants, meeting them where they are at, and navigating PPS systems on their behalf to deliver responses to their concerns are an important part of building trust between the District and the PPS community and ensuring that complainants receive their due process rights.